WHILE HE QUIETLY sat through Nehru's speech that questioned many of the fundamental political assumptions he had held for at least a decade, Jinnah may have pondered over what got him to this point. Long before Jawaharlal had entered the political arena with his radical politics to oust British colonialists from India, Jinnah was widely hailed in Congress corners as the 'best ambassador of Hindu-Muslim Unity'.[22] He received this praise for engineering the Lucknow Pact of 1916, a joint declaration of the Muslim League and the Indian National Congress to increase Indian representation in the colonial services with a weighted role for Muslims. Jinnah's steady disenchantment with the Congress began in the late 1910s. It peaked in 1920 when Mahatma Gandhi captured control of the Congress with the help of pro-Khilafat Indian Muslims who saw him as an ally in their ambiguous cause to reinstate the Ottoman Caliphate after the First World War. Things came to a showdown at the Congress session of 1920 in Nagpur, where Gandhi proposed a change of the Congress constitution to include 'swaraj', or complete self-rule through the adoption of non-violent methods.[23]

Jinnah was not opposed to India's self-rule, but he considered Gandhi's methods ineffective and unnecessarily limiting in the future quest for independence. In Jinnah's words, adopting such practices that heavily relied on whipping up sentiments of the Congress's younger members was 'neither logical nor politically sound or wise'.[24] After a short speech at Nagpur, in which he contradicted the viewpoints of Gandhi, Jinnah was booed off the stage. An enraged audience accused him of 'weakness', 'slave mentality' and of being a 'political imposer'.[25] Disheartened by this backlash, Jinnah soon resigned his membership of the Congress. Despite the Nagpur incident, this resignation came as a surprise to many observers. They had speculated that Jinnah would have soon been the foremost political leader within the Congress party as an essential voice of the moderate wing to endorse the evolutionary process of demanding constitutional changes rather than immediate freedom from the colonial yoke.